

Gender and philosophy



The 'second-wave' feminism of the 1950s and 60s was inspired by Simone de Beauvoir's assertion that femininity is imposed on women by society (see [The Second Sex](#)). As well as the political Women's Liberation movement, there was considerable discussion by feminist philosophers, that continued into a so-called 'third wave' from the 1990s onwards. In the tradition of continental philosophy, this used post-structuralism and deconstruction to analyse discourse about and by women, in order to ascertain how male-dominated culture, including philosophy, shapes the way women are viewed and the way they view themselves. But there was

also some debate as to whether notions of gender are purely social constructs or whether there is in fact an intrinsic difference between the sexes beyond the purely physical. Gender studies emerged as a separate discipline, considering the role of sexuality in determining gender difference. The gradual acceptance of other sexualities at the time complicated the debate, since these did not fit neatly into traditional gender definitions.